

Reflections and Limitations

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My analysis showed an overall average reported GPA of 3.79 and an average of 3.78 among accepted Fall 2026 applicants. However, my two additional questions revealed lower reported GPAs among doctoral acceptances at highly selective universities: 3.13 for an international applicant at Carnegie Mellon and 3.00 for an American applicant at Stanford. These results illustrate how averages can hide variation within a dataset. They do not establish minimum admission requirements or show how likely applicants with similar GPAs are to receive offers. Grad Café relies on anonymous, voluntary submissions, which creates selection and self-reporting bias. Applicants with high scores or particularly positive, negative, or unusual outcomes may be more likely to post, while others may not appear at all. Missing GPAs, incorrect entries, and inconsistent reporting can further affect the calculations. Consequently, these results describe the submitted records and may not represent the wider applicant population.

This analysis also highlights the distinction between digital data and the reality it is intended to represent. Digital records can serve as a proxy for real-world events, but they provide an incomplete and potentially distorted account of those events. Grad Café data can still support useful analysis, provided that we acknowledge these limitations and keep our conclusions within what the evidence supports. Recognizing uncertainty does not remove bias, and a mathematically correct query can still produce a misleading picture when its underlying data is unrepresentative. This concern also applies to artificial intelligence: if similarly biased or incomplete data is used to train models, those models may reproduce its distortions in their responses. Because people worldwide may use these responses to shape their expectations and decisions, careful attention to representation and real-world uncertainty is essential.